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HST 243: Soviet History Through Film

09.03.2026

How, and to what extent, did Soviet films made in the 1920s and 1930s reflect ideological agendas?

An ideological agenda can be defined as a state-driven program that encompasses and reflects the interests of the ruling party in political, social, and economic domains. Ideological objectives are institutionalized and spread along the areas of interest using various vehicles of mass communication, including cinema. As remarked by Rosenstone, films are often recognized as fanciful or ideological renditions of history, which have a profound effect on the viewers¹. Given its saturation with ideological narratives, Soviet cinematography of the 1920s and 1930s offers a valuable case study for examining the following phenomenon. Speaking specifically, Soviet films produced in the interwar period between the 1920s and 1930s reflect the state's main ideological agenda of enforcing industrialization, with modernization, the promotion of literacy, and the creation of the new Soviet people serving as its key facilitators. Industrialization was the central ideological objective at the time, as it arose from the Soviet war scare and appeared as the only adequate method of preparing the country for what would later become the Second World War.

Soviet filmography of the 1920s-1930s propagated technical and social modernization as necessary prerequisites for industrialization. In other words, movies produced in the given period showcased modernization as an indispensable part of industrialization, which would ensure progress and unity under Soviet rule. The primary method of acquiring modernization was the eradication of the perceived cultural backwardness of diverse communities within the Soviet

¹ Rosenstone, Robert. "History on Film" In *History on Film/Film on History*, (Routledge: 2018), 4.

Union. This principle was implemented most prominently in the eastern republics, whose indigenous practices were deemed incompatible with Soviet ideological priorities. According to Stalin, these republics were meant to be drawn into the work of building all-union socialism through the fulfillment of immediate civilizing tasks such as creating industrial centers, developing agriculture, organizing labor cooperatives, etc². The necessity of Soviet modernization found its manifestation in *Salt for Svanetia*, which presented the destructive and amoral nature of traditional customs. The film explicitly endorsed the image of cultural rituals as hazardous remnants of the pre-revolutionary era, primarily through the depiction of the religious procession during a funeral and a heavily pregnant woman forced out of her home (Figure 1).



Figure 1. Sequence of scenes with the religious procession and a pregnant woman from

Salt for Svanetia

By intercutting scenes of enterprising priests driven by greed with the agony of a woman, Kalatozov subtly advanced the idea that human life, from its beginning to the very end, is miserable when lived in accordance with indigenous customs. In this case, traditional life appeared in the movie as a result of geographical and ideological isolation that perpetuated

² Stalin, Joseph. "The Political Tasks of the University of the Peoples of the East" In *Works*, no. 115 (Pravda: 1925), 136.

continuous suffering and prevented societal progress. *Salt for Svanetia* ultimately demonstrated that Soviet modernization was a solution for this cycle of stagnation and hardship by framing construction of the road as a symbol of overcoming backwardness. It is worth mentioning that dynamic explosions that accompanied the construction process served as a representation of the annihilation of the traditional lifestyle for the sake of industrialization (Figure 2). According to Widdis, these explosions destroyed old buildings of Ushkul that trapped Svans in the past, marking the domination of man over both nature and historical stasis³. At this point, Soviet modernization was portrayed as a force capable of liberating ethnic groups from the confinements of the past and mobilizing them for industrial labor.



Figure 2. Explosion from *Salt for Svanetia*

A similar tendency was evident in *Turksib*, where Soviet modernization was likewise portrayed as the primary means of overcoming backwardness. With that being said, contrary to Kalatozov, Turin envisioned the triumph of Soviet civilizing efforts as an integrative process, rather than the annihilation of existing indigenous practices and customs. Speaking specifically, modernization in *Turksib* appeared as a synthesis of Soviet industrial ambitions and pastoralist nomads, which united the new dynamic technology with the vitality of natural life (embodied by

³ Widdis, Emma. "Socialist Transformations" In *Socialist Senses: Film, Feeling, and the Soviet Subject, 1917–1940*, (Indiana University Press: 2017), 275.

Kazakhs)⁴. This was most clearly illustrated in the scene of nomads chasing the train, with the railway being a symbolic path from backwardness to development under Soviet guidance. While racing alongside the train, one Kazakh deliberately dismounted his camel and continued running on foot (Figure 3).



Figure 3. Kazakhs chasing the train from *Turksib*

The following sequence was presented in the film as a logical transition of Central Asia into a more technical and industrialized phase of its history, instead of an explosive eradication of the past. Regardless of these minor differences, both movies promoted all-union modernization as the first step towards complete industrialization, aligning with the state's major ideological objectives of the 1920s-1930s.

Furthermore, Soviet films produced in the interwar period emphasized the importance of promoting literacy to sustain not only educated but also ideologically trained cadres needed for industrialization. In the context of the 1920s-1930s, education functioned as a primary medium of political indoctrination, which the state employed to cultivate a disciplined industrial proletariat. As it was stated by Lunacharskii, "In essence, no scholarly nor technical subject

⁴ Widdis, "Socialist Transformations", 268.

exists that isn't related to the idea of communism or to communist construction.”⁵ Drawing on this perspective, the promotion of literacy was never a neutral, enlightening initiative but an ideologically driven program aimed at sustaining individuals aligned with the strategic objectives of the party. This phenomenon found its realization in *Turksib*, where Kazakhs were depicted learning to read (Figure 4).



Figure 4. Kazakhs learning to read from *Turksib*

It is important to note that in the film, educating nomads was presented as a matter of equal importance as technically training them to operate agricultural machinery and build railways. The inseparability of enlightenment and technical training demonstrated the gradual process of pastoralists becoming industrial laborers, thereby integrating into the broader Soviet workforce. The following transformation was further highlighted by Payne, who claimed that in 1930 alone, 2,700 Kazakhs were enrolled in the introductory reading and writing courses within the established illiteracy eradication bases⁶. As a result of these educational initiatives, by 1934, Kazakhs accounted for 64% of coal miners, 74% of oil workers, and 82% of leather craftsmen of

⁵ Lunacharskii, Anatolii. “Communist Propaganda and Public Enlightenment” In *Problems of National Education*, ed. 2, trans. Mollie Arbuthnot, (Rabotnik prosveshcheniia: 1925), 4.

⁶ Payne, Matt. “The Forge of the Kazakh Proletariat? The Turksib, Nativization, and Industrialization during Stalin’s First Five-Year Plan” In *A State Of Nations: Empire and Nation-Making in the Age of Lenin and Stalin*, (Oxford University Press: 2001), 238.

the republic⁷. More significantly, with the progression of ideologically conditioned professional training, Kazakhs began to reconsider their self-determination and disengage from traditional notions, with one worker stating “We are not from a clan, we are proletarians.”⁸ At this point, the promotion of literacy appeared as a crucial instrument for fostering industrialization not only because it produced technically capable cadres but also resulted in the ideological shift of identity among members of communities initially classified as backward.

However, enlightenment campaigns were not limited strictly to eastern republics but rather emerged as an omnipresent policy encompassing all parts of the Soviet Union. To be exact, promotion of literacy under Soviet rule targeted ‘backward elements’ in all their manifestations, including Russian peasants⁹. The titular character Chapaev served as the embodiment of Soviet educational mobilization among ordinary Russians, which was especially evident in his dialogue with Furmanov about outstanding commanders. Being introduced to the historical figure of Alexander the Great, Chapaev confessed his lack of knowledge to the commissar “Я ведь только два года как грамоте знаю. Слышь, комиссар, ты мне Расскажи про Александра Македонского.” In the movie, Chapaev’s limited literacy functioned as a crucial cinematographic element that conveyed two major ideas. First, it underscored that Soviet enlightenment offered vast opportunities for people of humble social backgrounds to rise to prominent positions. Secondly, it effectively highlighted the eagerness of Soviet cadres for knowledge while emphasizing their unquestioning ideological devotion to the Bolshevik party. To illustrate, when asked about his political affiliation, Chapaev replied “Ну за тот [интернационал], который нужно, за тот и стою.” In this case, the movie subtly implied that

⁷ Payne, “The Forge of the Kazakh Proletariat?”, 241.

⁸ Payne, “The Forge of the Kazakh Proletariat?”, 241.

⁹ Fitzpatrick, Sheila. “Palaces on Monday” In *Everyday Stalinism: Ordinary Life in Extraordinary Times : Soviet Russia in the 1930s*, (Oxford University Press: 2000), 80.

Soviet people should be less concerned with underlying political complexities and adopt the character's unconditional loyalty instead. The portrayal of Chapaev reinforced the notion that education was inseparable from political indoctrination in the training of literate and ideologically committed workers needed to undertake industrialization.

In addition, Soviet movies of the 1920s and 1930s promoted the image of a 'new Soviet person' as a central figure in facilitating industrialization. More precisely, interwar cinematography visualized and propagated key characteristics aligned with the conventions of industrialization that modern Soviet citizens were expected to embrace, thereby constructing the notion of the 'new Soviet person.' In this case, directors and screenwriters functioned as the "engineers of souls"¹⁰ by conditioning and preparing the public for participation in industrialization through the medium of film. For instance, *Man with a Movie Camera* offered a unique vision of a 'new Soviet person' as an individual representing the spirit and dynamics of technological modernity. According to Gillespie, Vertov presented the main character as a 'perfect electric man,' who embodied the primacy of the machine and transcended the limitations of the 'imperfect human form.'¹¹ The immersion of a man with the camera enabled him to observe various people, places, and processes across the Soviet Union, demonstrating his omnipresent vision. Nevertheless, in the film, a man with a movie camera appeared not only as the passive spectator or the narrator but rather as an indispensable member of the industrial world. This idea was articulated by Vertov through repeated visual analogies between the camera operator and industrial working sites (Figure 5).

¹⁰ Zhdanov, Andrei. "Soviet Literature - The Richest in Ideas, the Most Advanced Literature" In *Soviet Writers Congress 1934*, (Lawrence & Wishart: 1977), 5.

¹¹ Gillespie, David. "Dziga Vertov: Life 'Caught Unawares'" In *Early Soviet Cinema: Innovation, Ideology and Propaganda*, (Wallflower: 2000), 81.

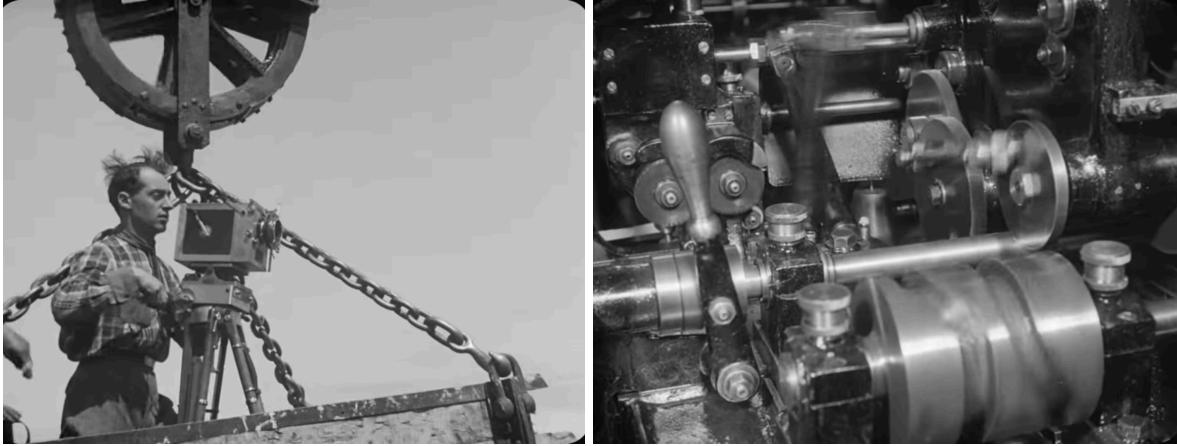


Figure 5. Sequence of scenes of a man with a movie camera and factory from *Man with a Movie Camera*

Speaking specifically, symmetrical composition allowed the director to effectively interweave scenes of a cameraman with ordinary workers, blurring the distinction between the two¹². In this way, a man with a camera was depicted as an equal laborer to coal miners, factory staff, and others, successfully integrating into the broader industrial workforce. Based on the following movie, one could conclude that the ‘new Soviet person’ in Vertov’s interpretation was someone deeply engaged with technology while remaining an equal member of industrialization as any other worker.

The concept of the ‘new Soviet person’ was further elaborated in *Chapaev*, where the main character exemplified the personal qualities and principles that viewers were to internalize. Whereas Vertov explored the place of the ‘new Soviet person’ in an industrial society driven by technology, the Vasilyev brothers focused on the internal virtues that defined this archetype. Despite the obvious differences between industrial and military service, Chapaev emerged as a universal role model due to his prioritization of the state’s interests above everything else,

¹² Hicks, Jeremy. "Man with a Movie Camera/Chelovek s kinoapparatom" In *The Russian Cinema Reader*, vol. 1, (Academic Studies Press: 2013), 186

including his very survival. By presenting his death as a tragic, yet heroic act, the directors implied that such selflessness was worthy of praise and recognition (Figure 6).



Figure 6. Chapaev drowning from *Chapaev*

Overall, the commander's bravery, moral fortitude, and commitment to his army were showcased in the film as traits every Soviet person should adopt. At this point, it is worth acknowledging the success the movie had in influencing and persuading the public to internalize Chapaev's character. As it was stated by Fitzpatrick, in 1937, when asked about their plans for the future, Soviet adolescents expressed the desire to emulate their favorite heroes such as Chapaev, Chkalov, Stalin, and others¹³. Taken together, *Man with a Movie Camera* and *Chapaev* outlined a detailed characterization of the 'new Soviet person' as a courageous individual integrated into technological and industrial processes, who places the interests of the state above personal concerns.

Soviet cinematography of the interwar period directly reflected the state's central ideological agenda of fostering industrialization by articulating the importance of modernization, literacy development, and the promotion of the 'new Soviet person' archetype. Driven by the Soviet war scare and the threat of the Second World War, modernization became the first step in

¹³ Fitzpatrick, "Palaces on Monday", 73.

integrating backward regions into all-union industrialization, which Soviet movies presented as liberating and civilizing. Furthermore, educational initiatives were portrayed by different directors as an effective measure of political indoctrination aimed at cultivating technically capable and ideologically committed industrial workers. Finally, the medium of film was utilized to construct the notion of the 'new Soviet person,' which served as an exemplary framework for the public. In this way, Soviet films of the 1920s and 1930s depicted a linear progression in which backward and illiterate communities transformed into technically and intellectually capable cadres, ultimately resulting in the emergence of the new archetype.

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Filmography

Chapaev [Чапaeв] (1934), dir. Georgi Vasilyev & Sergei Vasilyev

Man with a Movie Camera [Человек с киноаппаратом] (1929), dir. Dziga Vertov

Salt for Svanetia [Соль Сванетии] (1930), dir. Mikhail Kalatozov

Turksib [Турксиб] (1929), dir. Viktor Turin